ATV, SxS & Dirt Bike Safety Guide

Safety essentials for ATV, UTV, SxS, and dirt bike riding in Pierce County, Washington

Pierce County has growing OHV (off-highway vehicle) access with designated WATV roads and nearby trail systems. Our SAR unit operates ATVs and dual sport motorcycles on missions, so we know this terrain well. Here's what you need to ride safely.

Where to Ride in Pierce County

Pierce County WATV Roads

Approximately 354 miles of county roads in the south and east sections of unincorporated Pierce County are approved for Wheeled All-Terrain Vehicle (WATV) use on roads with speed limits of 35 mph or less. WATVs are NOT permitted on state highways, forest service roads, national parks, or city streets unless specifically approved.

Elbe Hills ORV Area

Located near Elbe (south Pierce County). Offers 13 miles of motorized trails and a 20-site campground. Mix of single-track and double-track trails through DNR-managed forest land. Great for beginners and families.

Nearby: Walker Valley (Skagit County)

A popular destination for Pierce County riders willing to make the drive. 36 miles of trails including single-track for motorcycles, double-track for ATVs, and 4x4 trails. Well-maintained DNR site with staging areas.

SAR PRO TIP

Download the Pierce County ATV/UTV Association's road map (piercecountyatv.org) before riding. It shows exactly which roads in each township are open to WATVs. Riding on non-approved roads can result in fines and contributes to access closures.

Washington State OHV Laws

- ☐ Helmet: DOT-approved helmet required for ALL riders/passengers on public land. No exceptions.
- ☐ Registration: ORV registration decal required. WATV metal plate for street-legal use.
- ☐ Age restrictions: Under 13: must be directly supervised by licensed adult 18+. 13+: supervised on non-highway roads.
- ☐ Passengers: Only on vehicles designed for multiple riders. No doubling up on single-seat ATVs.
- ☐ Spark arrestor: USFS-approved spark arrestor required. Check your exhaust system.
- ☐ Sound: Muffler required, must not exceed 105 dB at 20 inches.
- ☐ Headlights: Required during hours of darkness or poor visibility conditions.
- ☐ Alcohol: Operating under the influence carries the same penalties as a DUI.

Riding Safety

Before Every Ride

- ☐ T-CLOCS check: Tires, Controls, Lights, Oil, Chassis, Stands
- ☐ Helmet, goggles, gloves, boots, long sleeves, riding pants — every ride
- ☐ Know the trail difficulty before committing. Turn back if over your head.
- ☐ Check fire danger level and burn bans (Industrial Fire Precaution Levels)
- ☐ Carry a basic tool kit, tire repair, and first aid kit

On the Trail

Ride within your ability. Speed is the leading cause of ATV/SxS injuries. Keep right on shared trails and announce yourself on blind corners. Be alert for logging trucks and other vehicles on forest roads — they can't stop quickly. Never ride alone in remote areas.

SxS / UTV Specific

Always wear seatbelts in enclosed SxS vehicles. Roll cages only protect you if you're strapped in. Keep all limbs inside the cage. Rollover risk increases on side-slopes — lean uphill and reduce speed on off-camber terrain. Doors/nets should be secured.

SAR PRO TIP

We respond to a significant number of ATV/SxS incidents each year, and the overwhelming pattern is speed + unfamiliar terrain. Riders who are new to a trail system need to take it slow on the first pass. That blind corner could hide a downed tree, a washout, or an oncoming vehicle.

Emergency Preparedness

OHV areas are often remote with no cell service. Carry a satellite communicator or ensure you've signed up for T-Mobile's free satellite 911 texting. Always ride with a buddy and file a trip plan with someone who isn't riding with you.

IF SOMEONE IS INJURED

1) Ensure the scene is safe (engine off, vehicle stabilized).
2) Don't move the injured person unless there's immediate danger.
3) Call 911 (or text via satellite). Give your GPS coordinates.
4) Send someone to the nearest road to guide responders.
5) Keep the injured person warm and calm until help arrives.